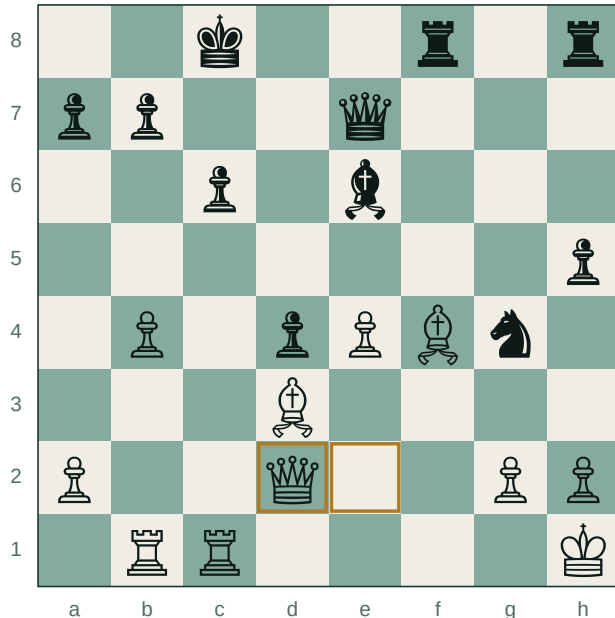


Clearance tactics: Black, move 22

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 22.Qd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Rxf4 23. Qxf4 Rf8 24. Qxf8+ Qxf8

22...Rxf4 The rook captures the bishop on f4. Recorded reply: **23.Qxf4**.

23...Rf8 The rook moves from h8 to f8. Recorded reply: **24.Qxf8+**.

24...Qxf8 The queen captures the queen on f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on h1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.